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Original Research Article

The Impact of Image, Role Models, Learning Approach, Course Content and Structure, and Course Delivery on the Entrepreneurial Motivation of University Students in Oman

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Abstract

This paper investigated students' perspectives toward entrepreneurship at the University of Technology and Applied Sciences during Semester 1, AY 2020-2021, when the COVID-19 pandemic was at its peak. The study's goal is to look into the major aspects that influence the respondents' inclinations toward entrepreneurship. The impact of role models, entrepreneurship's image, curriculum and content, personal learning approaches, and respondents' overall attitudes about motivation in pursuing entrepreneurial endeavors in the face of the epidemic. The results were interpreted using descriptive analysis, Cronbach Alpha was used to assess the questionnaire's dependability, multivariate statistical normality of skewness and kurtosis were used to assess normality, and a non-parametric test using the Mann-Whitney test was used to measure the p-value measuring the significance of results. Essentially, the numerous items examined yielded a favorable outcome; as a result of the findings, students are more likely to engage in entrepreneurial activities.

Keywords: Entrepreneurial, Approach, Content, Delivery.

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1 INTRODUCTION

After graduation, or for anyone who is already frustrated or exhausted working for an organization, the prospect of entrepreneurship or the establishment of small enterprises is always an alternative. People in Oman are talking about and exploring the idea of entrepreneurship in all sectors these days; the government has spearheaded many programs to encourage interest in the field, and policymakers, private organizations, chambers of commerce, the women's sector, academics, and college students have all expressed interest. Self-employment has become a viable choice in Oman, where unemployment remains an issue since it is a more appealing and gratifying career option for people, particularly university or college students and graduates.

Entrepreneurship is a critical component of a country's economic development, innovation, and competitiveness (Scarborough and Zimmerer, 2003; Kuratko and Hodgetts, 2004). According to Lee, Chang, and colleagues (2005), this has made entrepreneurship among the most investigated issues in academic circles in terms of assessing its significance and contributions. As consequence, students are increasingly looking for ways to learn how to operate a business or create jobs (Brown 1999; Henry, 2003). Institutions of higher learning throughout the world had created and encouraged entrepreneurship as a discipline and an employment option in this regard (Postigo and Tamborini, 2002.

The purpose of this study was to analyze the entrepreneurial motives of students at the University of Technology and Applied Sciences. The research

summarized the respondents' profiles, assessed their entrepreneurial motives, identified the characteristics that drove students to engage in entrepreneurial endeavors and desire to do so and evaluated the subject's role in encouraging entrepreneurship. The study's findings will give ideas for persuading students to pursue entrepreneurship.

Entrepreneurship education is a fundamental method used by educational institutions to encourage students to pursue entrepreneurial goals (Linan 2004). Entrepreneurship has been integrated into the curriculum of educational institutions, and assistance may be found in a variety of contexts (EC, 2008). This program's most important requirement is that entrepreneurship is both taught and learned.

According to Resurrection (2011), entrepreneurship is being explored by many emerging and impoverished nations as a possible solution to poverty challenges. Many governments have not been slow to implement programs and activities to support entrepreneurial endeavors, particularly among the young, to urge them to participate actively in the fight against poverty. Progress has been uneven, students' perspectives appear to be still concerned with economic participation.

It's worth noting that academic institutions have a huge difficulty in developing students' entrepreneurial competencies and abilities when it comes to curriculum and instructional techniques (Garavan and O'Cinneide 1994). Entrepreneurship is a professional option that allows students to gain financial independence while also benefiting the economy by contributing to job creation, innovation, and economic growth. Entrepreneurship is a way to diversify the Oman economy, and young people, particularly graduates and students, may assist drive or stimulating everyone in reaching financial independence and benefiting the economy by contributing to job creation, innovation, and economic growth.

2. METHODOLOGY

The questionnaire's dependability was assessed using descriptive analysis and a reliability assessment via Cronbach Alpha. Univariate and multivariate normality of skewness and kurtosis were used to assess normality, and a non-parametric test, the Mann-Whitney test, was employed to generate the p-value, which was used to assess the evidence against the study's goals.

Participants

Students enrolled in Entrepreneurship during Semester 3 2020-2021 at the University of Technology and Applied Sciences, Shinas, Oman, were the study's participants. The link to the online survey using Google Forms was given to 94 target respondents. Only 88 replies from students were declared legitimate after validation since certain critical items were left blank or unanswered.

Data Analysis

Using descriptive analysis, the data were tabulated and evaluated. The questionnaire's dependability was assessed using a Cronbach Alpha reliability scale. Univariate and multivariate normality of skewness and kurtosis were used to assess normalcy, and a non-parametric test, the Mann-Whitney test, was employed to generate the p-value, which was used to assess the evidence against the study's goals. For each closed-ended question, the scales used in the questionnaire were based on a 5-point Likert scale (1=strongly disagree, 2=disagree, 3=no opinion, 4=agree, 5=strongly agree).

3. RESULTS

88 valid responses were used for analysis in the study out of the 94 submitted responses. The male outnumbered the male respondents from 49 to 39, male to female ratio of 55.7 % against 44.3 %. The respondents were comprised of 58 (65.9 %) Engineering students, and 30 (24.1%) IT students.

Table 1: Reliability Analysis of key variables Using Cronbach Alpha

S. No.	Key Variable	Alpha Coefficient
1	Entrepreneurial Inclination (EI)	0.827
2	Image of Entrepreneurship (IE)	0.869
3	Role Models (RM)	0.837
4	Entrepreneurial Curriculum and Content (ECC)	0.949
5	Personal Independent Learning Approach (PIL)	0.769
6	Entrepreneurship Internship Programs (EIP)	0.875

The reliability scale of the data set gathered was highly reliable using Cronbach Alpha where the PIL shows the lowest at 0.769 and entrepreneurial curriculum content registered high reliability of 0.949. This shows that the variables used for correlation analysis are reliable.

Measurement of Central Tendencies

The results reveal that the highest mean and highest standard deviation (SD) for professional development (PD) are 4.333 and 0.9337, respectively. The lowest mean and lowest SD for PD are 3.555 and 0.6794, respectively. The range of mean 3.555–4.333 shows that the responses among PD items are between 'neutral' to 'strongly agree'. The lowest and highest

means for professional skills (PDS) are 4.1852 and 4.2593, while the lowest SD and highest SD are 0.55726 and 0.665590, respectively. The mean range 4.1852 - 4.2593 shows positive responses to all the items of PDS ranging from agreeing to strongly agree. The lowest mean and lowest SD for personal growth (PR) are 3.7778 and 0.62017, whereas the highest mean and highest SD are 4.3333 and 0.89156, respectively. The mean range of 3.7778 –4.3333 indicates that business students "agreed" with all the items of PG. The lowest and highest means for personal capabilities (PRS) are 4.2222 and 4.4444, the while lowest SD and highest SD are 0.56488 and 0.72403, respectively. The mean range 4.222–4.444 shows positive responses between agreeing and strongly agreeing for personal ability.

Multivariate Normality Test

The acceptable skewness range is ± 3 with an acceptable kurtosis range of ± 10. The data of the study will be normally distributed if values of kurtosis and skewness fall within this range. These results show that critical values of kurtosis range from − 1.123 (EIP3) to -.014 (EIP1), whereas critical values of skewness range from − 0.782 (EI5) to 0.159 (EIP5). The results indicate that all the values of kurtosis and skewness fall in the acceptable range; therefore, the data of the study are normally distributed.

Table 2: Skewness and kurtosis test

	Skewness		**Kurtosis**	
Lowest	-.782 (EI5)		-1.123 (EIP3)	
Highest	.159 (EIP5)		-.014 (EIP1)	
	Mean	**Std. Deviation**	**Skewness**	**Kurtosis**
EI5	3.9886	1.11926	-.782	-.402
IE2	3.7841	1.10847	-.491	-.693
IE3	3.9773	1.05020	-.746	-.140
EIP1	3.7159	.97023	-.479	-.014
EIP2	3.7045	.93660	-.316	-.334
EIP3	3.8068	.96916	-.142	-1.123
EIP4	3.8409	1.01581	-.413	-.667
EIP5	2.8068	1.34641	.159	-1.056

Non-parametric test results

The results of the Mann-Whitney U test show that the influence of role models, the image of entrepreneurship, curriculum and content, personal learning approach, and the overall attitude of the respondents motivates entrepreneurial endeavor among the students amid the pandemic The results further show that the students positively responded that entrepreneurship is a viable career option during the pandemic and beyond. The level of significance ranges from 0.052 (EI2) to 0.996 (ECC7).

Table 3: Mann-Whitney U Test

	EI1	**EI2**	**EI6**	**IE1**	**IE2**	**RM1**	**RM2**	**ECC2**	**ECC7**
Mann-Whitney	848	656	869	827	859	808	836	869	870
Wilcoxon W	2559	2367	2580	1292	2570	2519	2547	2580	1335
Z	-.203	-1.946	-.009	-.404	-.105	-.568	-.315	-.009	-.005
Asymp. Sig. (2-tailed)	.839	.052	.993	.687	.916	.570	.753	.993	.996

4. CONCLUSION

During the pandemic, the research examined many characteristics that have a role in entrepreneurial drive among students at the University of Technology and Applied Sciences. The findings of the study, in general, support the function of entrepreneurial education, image, role, curriculum and content, learning style, and course delivery in encouraging entrepreneurship (Edwards and Muir 2005; Postigo, Iacobucci, *et al.*, 2006; Nurmi and Paasio 2007). This association might be explained by students' increased need for high-quality education from educational institutions that can prepare them for employment prospects by equipping them with entrepreneurial skills. Additionally, the data show that institutions of higher learning encourage students to develop entrepreneurial cultures while they are in university. In this context, Higher Education Institutions (HEI) must build an atmosphere that fosters and encourages the culture of entrepreneurship.

Students' enthusiasm for entrepreneurship is influenced by their exposure to entrepreneurial courses. The findings emphasized the relevance of academic institutions in fostering self-employment. The university assists students in developing an entrepreneurial mindset. In order to encourage students to become entrepreneurs, HEI should establish an entrepreneurial atmosphere. Entrepreneurship should be integrated into the teaching-learning process, and students should be prepared to start their businesses.

The needs of students and the industry's expectations will be aligned with a well-designed program. Students' motivation to pursue business would be aided by exposure to entrepreneurial courses. This study suggests that higher education institutions have a favorable impact on students' interest in entrepreneurship. Through the study of entrepreneurship, HEIs play a critical role in promoting the value of self-employment. Experiential learning via entrepreneurship motivates students to start their businesses. In this context, HEIs' instructional initiatives must include visits to business ventures, the engagement of entrepreneurs as guest speakers to talk about their experiences, and the organizing of various activities that ignite students' interest.

The development of entrepreneurship course delivery or syllabi should transition from lecture and practical learning. It is also suggested that the course materials and content be tailored to the current business environment. Competency-based pedagogical methods for entrepreneurship should be used, with an emphasis on a student-centered learning approach. Every curriculum should include the enabling aspects and dimensions, such as the value orientation required for entrepreneurship. Furthermore, academic institutions must educate students about the value of entrepreneurship not only as an alternative career option but as a mainstream employment mechanism.

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